

Internet

The network that connected the world's computers, starting the INFORMATION REVOLUTION

Sharing computers

In 1969, the Advanced Research Projects Agency (ARPA) launched an **interconnected group of powerful computers**, and called it ARPANET.

This novel idea enabled scientists working anywhere in the United States to share these few computers **without leaving their own place of work**. Computer scientists Vint Cerf and Bob Kahn were two of the key experts working on the project in the 1970s.

Packet switching

ARPANET was a success, and it gradually spread outward to make a network of networks: what we now call the **INTERNET**. In 1973, Cerf and Kahn developed a language, called TCP/IP, to help the Internet function better. It relies on "packet switching": instead of sending data in one direction, through a central system, the data was **split into chunks** (or packets). Each packet found the most efficient way across the network to its destination, where the data was **reassembled**.

Vint Cerf helped develop the first commercial e-mail system.

If one computer server is busy, the data chooses a different route.

Computers connect to the Internet through an Internet Service Provider (ISP)'s computer.

How it changed the world

The Internet means we always have information at our fingertips, and can share information and communicate whenever we want.

Getting connected

Along with the invention of **E-MAIL** in 1972, TCP/IP allowed the Internet to really take off. It became the **standard Internet language** in 1983. Europe, via the Netherlands, became the first territory outside the US to connect to the Internet in 1989. By this time, there were less than 10 million computers connected to the Internet, but that **was about to change**.

